

All Research Proposals (P1 to P5)

P1. The Fuel Shock Panel — a rapid-response household phone panel (flagship)

Question. How do coping, well-being and trust in the state change over the fuel shock cycle, and how does that path differ between public-sector, formal-private and informal households?

Why it’s important. The 19/21 September timing splits households by sector, and a second hike is likely in Oct–Dec. A panel that starts now captures the baseline, the October “cliff”, Boro and LDC graduation in one dataset. Nothing like it exists for Bangladesh’s 2022 hike.

Design. - **Sample:** 1,500–2,500 households across Dhaka, Chattogram, Gazipur/Narayanganj (RMG belt), Rangpur and Rajshahi (Boro, diesel irrigation) and one coastal district. The sample is stratified by the main earner’s sector: government / formal private (incl. RMG) / informal non-farm (incl. transport) / farm. It is recruited from an existing sampling frame if a partner lends one (BIGD, SANEM or a survey firm). Otherwise use random-digit dialling with quotas. - **Waves:** W0 now (baseline, by mid-Oct) → W1 Nov → W2 Jan → W3 Mar → W4 Jun 2027 (after the Boro harvest). Each is a 15–20 min CATI (phone) interview. - **Core modules:** - spending cuts, measured with a list of 12 items, each ranked 1st/2nd/3rd - food insecurity (FIES, 8 items) - transport mode, time and cost for the main commute - kerosene/lighting and study hours - borrowing - intra-household allocation (who ate less) - relative deprivation (comparison to government employees) - blame - trust in institutions - protest willingness and participation - Family Card receipt - **Embedded experiment in W0:** randomise the explanation shown before asking whether the hike is acceptable: (a) nothing, (b) “global oil prices doubled”, (c) “Tk 32/L of the price is government duty”, (d) “government employees just received a pay rise”. This measures how *framing* and *perceived fairness* shift acceptance, which is the moral-economy test.

Analysis. Panel fixed effects. Compare trajectories between sectors (difference-in-differences with sector × wave). Heterogeneity by gender of respondent and income tercile. Treatment effects for the framing experiment.

Outputs. A public dashboard updated after each wave, policy briefs timed before the Boro and budget decisions, and 2–3 papers (coping, relative deprivation, moral economy).

Budget (indicative). ~\$35–60k for 5 waves at ~\$4–6 per completed CATI interview, plus the analyst, the survey firm’s management fee and incentives (Tk 50–100 mobile top-up per wave).

Risk. Phone surveys under-represent the poorest and women. Mitigate with quotas, asking for women respondents specifically, and a small in-person top-up.

P2. Charging the City — an ethnography of the e-rickshaw economy under load shedding

Question. How do battery-rickshaw drivers, garage owners, charging-point operators and local power brokers govern an illegal energy economy? How does the fuel hike redistribute risk and income across that chain?

Design. - **Sites:** 3 neighbourhoods in Dhaka (one core, one peri-urban, one where a crackdown or relocation is active) and 1 district town. - **Methods:** - 4–6 months of participant observation at garages and charging points - 60–80 life-history interviews with drivers, sampled for ex-farmers, ex-RMG workers, returned migrants and women in the business (very rare, so an important case) - driver **daily diaries** (earnings, fares, charging costs, rent, “costs to police or fixers”, hours) over 8 weeks, collected via WhatsApp voice notes, with a small stipend - mapping of charging points to cross-check the reported 48,136 illegal vs 3,300 authorised - **Mixed-method add-on:** a structured survey of 400 drivers at charging points to estimate the share who moved into rickshaws from each prior occupation.

Outputs. An ethnographic paper on informal energy governance, a policy note on legalisation and metering (lever #5 in the README), and a photo-essay (with consent).

Budget. ~\$15–30k (researcher stipend, RA, diaries, transcription, translation).

P3. Boro Decisions — farmers, water sellers and the irrigation cost shock

Question. How do diesel costs, supply uncertainty and a frozen procurement price change farmers’ decisions about how much Boro to plant? Who in the agrarian hierarchy absorbs the cost?

Design. - **Sites:** 6 villages in 2–3 upazilas, in Rangpur, Rajshahi and Mymensingh (diesel shallow-tube-well heavy), with 1 grid/solar-irrigation village as a contrast. - **Data collection:** - a survey before planting (Nov) and at harvest (May), n~600 plots or farmers: tenure, planned vs actual area, irrigation arrangement and price, borrowing, household migration - interviews with pump owners and water sellers about how they set prices - focus groups with women in farming households on food and labour trade-offs - **Administrative data:** Department of Agricultural Extension (DAE) Boro area targets vs actuals, and BADC diesel/pump data if accessible.

Why it’s important. This is the channel most likely to turn into a 2027 food-price and forex problem. Almost no one is watching it yet (see §4c of the README).

Budget. ~\$20–35k.

P4. Who Gets the Blame? — computational analysis of public discourse on the fuel shock

Question. How are responsibility and fairness framed in Bangla-language public discourse about fuel between 2022 and 2026? Which frames predict offline protest?

Design. - **Corpus:** - Bangla and English news (Prothom Alo, Daily Star, TBS, Jugantor, Samakal, Kaler Kantho) - public Facebook pages and groups, YouTube comments on news clips, with platform terms and data-access rules followed - parliamentary debates - covering the 2022 hike, the April, June and September 2026 hikes, and the upcoming October–December 2026 events - **Methods:** - Bangla NLP: topic models, a frame classifier (global market / government failure / corruption-syndicate / India / fairness-pay scale / apology-empathy), sentiment - event data on protests (coded from news, ACLED where available) - time-series linking frame intensity to protest events and hike dates - **Validation:** human-coded sample (inter-coder reliability ≥ 0.7), plus a check against the P1 survey blame questions (the same framing categories).

Budget. Low: ~\$5–15k (RA coders, compute). The most feasible solo or remote project, and a strong companion paper to P1.

P5. Cash or Cheap Fuel? — a survey experiment on preferences for compensation

Question. Do Bangladeshis prefer universal cheap fuel or targeted cash compensation? How do trust in the state, perceived corruption and past experience with safety-net programmes shape that preference?

Design. - A conjoint experiment embedded in P1’s W1 or run on its own (n~2,000). - Respondents choose between policy packages that vary: fuel price (Tk 135/150/165), compensation (none / Tk 500 / Tk 1,000 per month), targeting (universal / Family Card / employer-based), delivery (bKash/Nagad / union parishad / NGO), and who pays (duty cut / budget / BPC borrowing). - Moderators: sector, prior safety-net receipt, trust, partisanship.

Why it’s important. It directly informs the choice the government faces in Oct–Dec. It adds evidence from Bangladesh to the international literature (Iran 2010, Indonesia, Nigeria 2023) on why fuel subsidy reform so often fails politically.

Budget. ~\$8–15k standalone, and small if embedded in P1.
